



New Zealand

MADE UP OF TWO MAIN ISLANDS and several smaller ones, New Zealand is one of the most isolated countries in the world. Located in the southern Pacific, the country has a mild climate, with warm summers and cool, wet winters. Both main islands have mountains, short, swift-flowing rivers, forests, and fertile farmland. Until the Europeans arrived, most of the landscape was covered in dense forest, known as native bush. Today, although forests remain, much has been cleared for farming. Most New Zealanders live on North Island, which is warmer and less mountainous. Although New Zealanders are of mainly British descent, the Maoris – a people of Polynesian origin – were the first to arrive about 1,000 years ago. Today, non-Maori Polynesians and Asians are adding to the ethnic mix. The country has a liberal, clean, green image and a high standard of living.

AUCKLAND

With its safe harbor and nearby scenic islands, Auckland is known as the "city of sails." It boasts more pleasure boats per person than anywhere else in the world. The water that separates the bigger islands is home to dolphins, families of blue penguins, and the occasional whale.

MAORI CULTURE

Maoris make up almost 14 per cent of the population, with most living on North Island. Before the coming of the *Pakeha* (white man), Maori history was passed on orally to succeeding generations. This included many legends and *waiata* (songs). Their carvings in wood (left) and stone (right) were another way they recorded and remembered events. In recent years, interest in Maori culture has increased, and school children are now taught the Maori language.



Greenstone (jade) carving, an example of Maori art



*In 1893,
New Zealand was
the first country
to give women
the vote.*

